



GONDWANA RAINFOREST

Only remnants of these southern supercontinent forests survive, with prehistoric ferns and conifers and ancient flowering plants. Among birds, the lyrebird, bowerbird, and catbird lineages stretch back more than 60 million years.



GREAT MOUNTAIN RANGE

More than 2,200 miles (3,500 km) long, the continent's only major uplands moisten the climate to the east, while aridity increases westwards.

MURRAY-DARLING BASIN

Named for its two major rivers, the wetlands here are seasonal and ephemeral.

NEW ZEALAND ALPS



THE RED CONTINENT

Australasia

Australasia consists of the mainland, or large island, of Australia, together with Tasmania, New Zealand, the huge tropical island of New Guinea, and a few other nearby islands. All of these, aside from New Zealand, make up the Australian continent. It is the smallest of the continents and also, on average, the driest inhabited continent: about one-third has a desertlike climate and another third is semi-arid. On the mainland of Australia, appreciable rain falls only around the eastern margins, while the great interior, or outback, is often parched.

The Australian continent has a unique evolutionary history. It split from the rest of the southern supercontinent of Gondwana more than 80 million years ago, taking with it plants and animals common at the time, especially marsupial mammals. What are now the Australian mainland and New Guinea remained linked by land bridges until 6,000 years ago, when sea levels rose after the last ice age. Consequently, they share much of their wildlife, a high proportion of which consists of endemic species—most of the continent's plants and mammals and a high proportion of its birds are found nowhere else.

Much more isolated, lying more than 1,300 miles (2,100 km) to the southeast of the Australian mainland, is New Zealand. It, too, boasts many unique plants and animals, including kiwis and other flightless birds.

TASMANIA
Australia's southern island state has dense rainforest and cool deciduous woodlands. They provide refuges for species once also on the mainland, such as the Tasmanian devil.

Forming the backbone of New Zealand's South Island, the Southern Alps' rugged high terrain is glaciated, with deep valleys, pockets of forest, and plunging cliffs. Iconic species include the rock wren, kea, and great spotted kiwi. It is the highest mountain range in Australasia.

